



EMPLOYER RESOURCE · OSHA GENERAL INDUSTRY

What OSHA Looks For When They Walk In.

A practical guide for HR managers, safety coordinators, and plant managers — covering what to have ready before the inspection, what happens during it, and what to do in the 15-day window after.

Vince Lawrence · GigLine Safety & Compliance · OSHA 30-Hour Certified · 25+ Years in Manufacturing

SECTION 01 • PRE-INSPECTION READINESS

Before the Inspection

Most operations are not inspection-ready. The gaps OSHA finds most often are not on the floor — they are in the files. An inspector can issue citations based on documentation alone, without observing a single floor condition. The checklist below covers what will be requested within the first thirty minutes of arrival.

Written Programs

- Hazard Communication (HazCom) Program — current and facility-specific

29 CFR 1910.1200(e)(1)

- Lockout/Tagout (LOTO) Energy Control Program

29 CFR 1910.147(c)(4)

- Emergency Action Plan

29 CFR 1910.38(a)

- Personal Protective Equipment Hazard Assessment

29 CFR 1910.132(d)

- Respiratory Protection Program (if respirators are used)

29 CFR 1910.134(c)

- Bloodborne Pathogens Exposure Control Plan (if applicable)

29 CFR 1910.1030(c)

- Forklift / Powered Industrial Truck Safety Program

29 CFR 1910.178(l)

- Machine Guarding Program

29 CFR 1910.212

OSHA Logs and Records

- OSHA 300 Log — current, complete, and accessible to employees

29 CFR 1904.29

- OSHA 300A Annual Summary — certified and posted February 1 through April 30 each year

29 CFR 1904.32

- OSHA 301 Incident Reports — one per recordable injury or illness

29 CFR 1904.29(b)

Training Records

- Forklift operator certifications — current, dated, and signed
29 CFR 1910.178(l)(6)
 - HazCom training — documented per employee, with SDS access confirmation
29 CFR 1910.1200(h)
 - LOTO training records — authorized and affected employees listed separately
29 CFR 1910.147(c)(7)
 - Respiratory protection fit test records (if applicable)
29 CFR 1910.134(f)
 - Bloodborne pathogens training records (if applicable)
29 CFR 1910.1030(g)(2)
 - PPE training documentation — per employee, per hazard type
29 CFR 1910.132(f)
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Physical Readiness

- Egress routes clear — no blocked exits, exit signs unobstructed and illuminated
29 CFR 1910.37
- Fire extinguishers inspected monthly — inspection tags current
29 CFR 1910.157(e)
- Electrical panels accessible — 36-inch clearance maintained
29 CFR 1910.303(g)
- LOTO procedures posted at each piece of equipment requiring them
29 CFR 1910.147(c)(4)
- SDS binders accessible and current for all chemicals present on-site
29 CFR 1910.1200(g)(1)

SECTION 02 · DURING THE INSPECTION

During the Inspection

OSHA inspections follow a defined four-phase structure. Understanding each phase allows you to respond accurately and avoid actions that create additional exposure. Your behavior during the inspection is documented by the inspector — treat every interaction as part of the record.

01 OPENING CONFERENCE

The inspector presents credentials, explains the basis for the inspection, and outlines scope.

Designate your authorized employer representative before the walkaround begins. You may request a brief delay to assemble your team — a reasonable request is generally honored.

02 WALKAROUND INSPECTION

The inspector tours the facility with your representative, observing conditions, taking photographs, and measuring distances. Take parallel notes and photographs at every stop.

- Do not attempt to correct visible violations while the inspector is present.
- Do not block access to any area of the facility.
- Log every area visited, every question asked, and every item photographed.

03 EMPLOYEE INTERVIEWS

OSHA has the legal right to interview employees privately. Employees may speak with the inspector without supervisors present and cannot be directed on what to say. Interference with this process is itself a citable violation.

04 CLOSING CONFERENCE

The inspector summarizes preliminary findings. This is not the final citation — formal notice arrives by mail. You may provide clarifying information and ask questions. Do not sign anything at the closing conference without legal review.

05 CITATION ISSUANCE

Formal citations are mailed within six months of the inspection. Each citation identifies the specific CFR violation, proposed penalty amount, and required abatement date. The 15-day contest window begins from the date of receipt — not the date of inspection.

SECTION 02 · EMPLOYER REPRESENTATIVE GUIDE

Your Role During the Inspection

How you conduct yourself during the inspection matters. The inspector observes and documents employer behavior throughout the visit. The table below covers the most important do's and don'ts for the employer representative from opening conference through closing.

WHAT TO DO

- ✓ Accompany the inspector at all times during the walkaround
- ✓ Take your own notes and parallel photos at every stop
- ✓ Answer factual questions about operations accurately and concisely
- ✓ Request clarification if you do not understand a question
- ✓ Obtain the inspector's business card and badge number
- ✓ Contact your safety consultant immediately after opening conference

WHAT NOT TO DO

- ✗ Volunteer information beyond what is directly asked
- ✗ Make promises about correction timelines during the inspection
- ✗ Attempt to correct visible violations while the walkaround is active
- ✗ Interfere with or direct employee interviews in any way
- ✗ Sign anything at the closing conference without legal review
- ✗ Argue with or obstruct the inspector at any point

SECTION 03 · POST-INSPECTION RESPONSE

After the Inspection

The response window after an inspection is governed by two hard deadlines. Missing either one removes options that would otherwise be available to you.

Within 24 Hours of the Closing Conference

- Write a complete summary of the walkaround — every area visited, observation noted, and question asked
- Identify any immediately dangerous conditions and initiate corrective action
- Notify ownership and leadership of preliminary findings before citations arrive
- Contact your safety consultant to review findings and prepare a response strategy
- Secure all documentation the inspector reviewed — do not alter any records

Within 15 Days of Receiving Citations

- Review each citation against the applicable CFR standard to verify accuracy
- Determine which citations to accept, contest, or request informal conference on
- File a Notice of Contest within 15 days if you intend to dispute — this deadline is absolute
- Begin corrective action planning for accepted citations before the abatement deadline
- Document every corrective action taken — photographs, dates, and employee acknowledgments

HR-FACING CITATIONS

What Gets Found in the Files

These violations are found in HR and administrative records — not on the production floor. Each is documentation-based. Each is preventable. Penalty exposure is per violation, per inspection — and citations on the same day can stack.

CFR CITATION	VIOLATION	OWNS IT	PENALTY EXPOSURE
29 CFR 1904.29	OSHA 300 Log not current or not posted	HR / Safety	Up to \$16,550 per violation
29 CFR 1910.1200(h)	HazCom training records incomplete	HR	Up to \$16,550 per violation
29 CFR 1910.132(f)	PPE training not documented	HR / Operations	Up to \$16,550 per violation
29 CFR 1910.147(c)(7)	LOTO training records missing	HR / Safety	Up to \$16,550 per violation
29 CFR 1910.1200(e)	Written HazCom program not current	HR / Safety	Up to \$16,550 per violation
29 CFR 1904.32	300A Summary not certified or posted Feb–Apr	HR	Up to \$16,550 per violation

If This Checklist Exposed Gaps, You're Not Alone.

Most small operations in the NC Piedmont Triad are not inspection-ready.
GigLine finds the gaps before OSHA does.

FREE — NO EMAIL REQUIRED

Safety Check

Six questions. 90 seconds.
A fast picture of where your operation stands.

giglinecompliance.com/safety-check

FROM \$2,000

Compliance Readiness Visit

Floor walkthrough + full documentation review.
Written report with CFR citations in 48 hours.

giglinecompliance.com/compliance-readiness-visit

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